

Indian Army troops being inspected before leaving their posts in the Ladakh border region during the war between India and China, 1962. (© Hulton-Deutsch Collection/CORBIS/Corbis via Getty Images)

Meanwhile, 4 Infantry Division vacated Tawang on 23 October and it fell to the Chinese the next day. On 25 October the Chinese halted their offensive and offered a ceasefire and a mutual withdrawal to 20km from the Line of Actual Control, but India rejected the offer. Reorganizing its defences, the Indian Army placed troops in vital areas ahead of the Sela Pass, with 62 Infantry Brigade (20 Infantry Division) as the vanguard. The brigade was supported by 48 Infantry Brigade (20 Infantry Division) plus the independent 65 and 67 Infantry brigades, which were spread out between Sela, Dirang Dzong, Bomdila and Rupa.

During the tactical pause, China had built up its forces to three divisions and it used one division against Sela, the other two divisions carrying out an outflanking manoeuvre. At Sela, 4 GARH RIF held up the Chinese advance, but in a major Indian tactical lapse, 62 Infantry Brigade was ordered to fall back to Dirang and Bomdila and suffered heavy casualties at